1. Grains

According to tradition, in the year 450 BCE, a man embarked upon a ship travelling from Miletus to Abdera. It was to be a crucial journey for the history of knowledge.

The man was probably fleeing political turmoil in Miletus, where the aristocracy was violently seizing back power. Miletus had been a prosperous and flourishing Greek city, perhaps the principal city of the Greek world before the golden age of Athens and Sparta. It had been a busy commercial hub, dominating a network of almost a hundred colonies and commercial outposts, stretching from the Black Sea to Egypt. Caravans from Mesopotamia and ships from all over the Mediterranean arrived at Miletus, and ideas circulated.



Figure 1.1 The journey made by Leucippus of Miletus, the founder of the atomist school (circa 450 BCE).